



# Zenzele Guide

"Do it yourself — but not alone."

AI-powered student guidance & careers platform for South Africa

High-Level Business & Build Plan | May 2026

Zulu/Xhosa meaning: "Do it yourself"

Built for SA matric students

Proudly South African

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

# What is Zenzele Guide?

Zenzele Guide is a South African AI-powered web platform that helps matric and grade 11 students navigate the complex landscape of higher education, bursaries, and career opportunities. The name "Zenzele" is Zulu/Xhosa for "do it yourself" — paired with "Guide" it signals that students take charge of their own future, but never alone.

Unlike generic job boards or static university listing sites, Zenzele Guide uses artificial intelligence to cross-reference a student's matric results, APS score, interests, province, and financial situation against real university prospectuses, bursary requirements, and job listings — delivering personalised recommendations in minutes.

|                      |                  |                     |                     |
|----------------------|------------------|---------------------|---------------------|
| 26+                  | 140+             | 800+                | 600k                |
| Universities indexed | Colleges & TVETs | Bursaries available | SA matrics per year |

## The problem Zenzele Guide solves

- Hundreds of thousands of SA matrics have no idea what they qualify for
- University prospectuses are PDFs hidden across 26 different websites
- APS calculation is confusing and most students get it wrong
- NSFAS and bursary information is fragmented and hard to find
- Students from rural and township areas have no guidance counsellors
- Job listings for graduates and school-leavers are scattered across dozens of sites
- Learnerships and graduate programmes have no central SA-specific hub
- Accommodation near universities is not surfaced alongside study options
- First-generation students make expensive application mistakes
- Existing platforms are generic, Western-style, and not SA-native

### The Zenzele Guide solution

1. Student uploads matric results (PDF or manual entry) — AI extracts marks automatically.
2. Student selects interests, province, and financial situation.
3. AI calculates APS score and cross-references 26+ university prospectuses in real time.
4. Platform returns ranked university matches, qualifying bursaries, and accommodation options.
5. Integrated jobs board surfaces relevant learnerships, internships, and graduate programmes.

## PLATFORM OVERVIEW

# Four core modules

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## Student Portal

- Multi-step guided flow: upload results → pick interests → AI analysis → recommendations
  - Live APS calculator with subject mark entry or PDF upload
  - AI recommendation engine ranks universities, colleges, bursaries and accommodation
  - Personalised match score (%) for every institution based on student profile
  - Free for all South African students — no sign-up required to check options
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## Jobs & Opportunities Board

- Filterable listings: internships, learnerships, graduate programmes, bursaries, full-time
  - Province and keyword search across all SA employers and government departments
  - AI match score on every listing (uses student profile from portal)
  - Save listings, subscribe to WhatsApp/email job alerts by interest and province
  - Self-serve employer posting: free standard / R950 featured / R2,100 premium pinned
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## Admin Portal

- Upload university and college prospectuses as PDFs
  - Claude AI automatically extracts APS requirements, courses, fees, closing dates
  - Manage all job listings, bursary entries, and accommodation data
  - Track revenue: AdSense earnings, featured listing payments, sponsor placements
  - View platform analytics: daily students, popular institutions, top job searches
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## Public Content & SEO

- Homepage with how-it-works, stats, and student testimonials
  - Blog/guide pages ranking on Google: "Wits APS 2026", "NSFAS how to apply" etc.
  - Individual SEO pages for every institution, course, bursary, and job listing
  - These pages are the free traffic engine — each one ranks for long-tail SA search queries
  - Ad revenue generated from every page visit (Google AdSense)
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## BRAND IDENTITY

# The Zenzele Guide brand

## Name & meaning

"Zenzele" is Zulu and Xhosa for "do it yourself" or "self-reliance" — one of the most empowering words in SA culture. Paired with "Guide" it signals that the platform empowers students to take charge of their own future, without leaving them alone in the process.

## Taglines

- "Do it yourself — but not alone." (primary)
- "Your future. Your choice. Your guide."
- "Find your varsity. Find your path."
- "Built for every SA matric student."

## Voice & tone

- Empowering, not patronising
- SA-authentic — natural Zulu/Xhosa words
- Warm and direct — like a smart older sibling
- Short sentences, no corporate jargon
- Celebratory — every result is a possibility

## Brand colours

|                                                                                   |                                            |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
|  | <b>Zenzele Green</b><br>#1D9E75 — primary  |
|  | <b>Deep Umhlaba</b><br>#085041 — headings  |
|  | <b>Soft Izolo</b><br>#E1F5EE — backgrounds |
|  | <b>Ilanga Gold</b><br>#FAC775 — accent/CTA |
|  | <b>Neutral</b><br>CSS variable — surfaces  |

## Digital presence

- zenzeleguide.co.za — primary website
- @ZenzeleGuide — TikTok, Instagram, X
- ZenzeleGuide — Facebook page
- WhatsApp Channel: "Zenzele Guide SA"

## Brand personality

- Ubuntu spirit — community-driven, your success lifts your family
- First-generation champion — for students whose parents never attended varsity
- Trustworthy AI — the AI is a guide, not a gatekeeper
- Proudly South African — not a copy of a Western platform

BUSINESS MODEL & REVENUE

# How Zenzele Guide makes money

The platform is free for all students. Revenue comes from employers, advertisers, and institutions who want to reach a highly targeted audience of SA school-leavers and young graduates.

Display Advertising

Google AdSense

Ads served on every public page — university guides, bursary pages, job listings. Every visitor generates ad revenue. The student audience is highly valuable to banks, insurers, mobile networks, and education brands.

Featured Job Listings

Employer-paid

Companies and government departments pay to have listings featured at the top of search results. Standard listing: free. Featured: R950. Premium pinned: R2,100. Target: Eskom, Transnet, Anglo American, banks, DPSA.

Bursary Sponsor Placements

Bursary providers

Bursary providers (Anglo American, Sasol, NSFAS partners) pay for prominent placement on the bursary listings page and in AI recommendations. Positioned as "sponsored" but still editorially relevant.

Premium Student Tier

Subscription

Optional R49/month premium tier for students: PDF application checklist, deadline tracker, live AI chat support, saved searches, and priority recommendations. Free tier is always available.

University & College Partnerships

Institution partnerships

Institutions pay an annual partnership fee to have their prospectuses featured, their courses highlighted in recommendations, and their brand on the platform. Positions Zenzele Guide as the official student gateway.

## Revenue projections

| Timeline   | Monthly Revenue    | Key drivers                                       |
|------------|--------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| Month 1–2  | R800 – R2,000      | Google AdSense (ads on free traffic)              |
| Month 3–6  | R5,000 – R12,000   | Ads + featured job listings (R950/R2,100 each)    |
| Month 6–12 | R20,000 – R50,000  | Peak matric season traffic + bursary sponsors     |
| Year 2+    | R80,000 – R200,000 | University partnerships + premium tier + WhatsApp |

### The matric season advantage

South Africa has ~600,000 matric students writing exams every year. Results drop in January — that's the traffic tsunami. With a launch in August, Zenzele Guide builds 2 months of SEO momentum before results day.

November–January is peak revenue season when every matric student searches "where can I apply with my marks." This is the window.

Running costs at MVP stage: approximately R97/month. Revenue potential by month 6: R5,000–R12,000/month. Year 2 with university partnerships: R80,000–R200,000/month.

TECHNOLOGY

# Tech stack & infrastructure

The stack is chosen for zero upfront cost, maximum scalability, and full compatibility with the Cloudflare infrastructure already available. Every tool has a generous free tier — the entire MVP can be built and launched for ~R97/month.

| Layer        | Technology                        | Purpose                                       |
|--------------|-----------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| Frontend     | Next.js 14 + Tailwind CSS         | Website, student portal, SEO, dark mode       |
| Database     | Supabase (PostgreSQL)             | Institutions, students, jobs, results storage |
| AI engine    | Claude API (Sonnet)               | APS matching, PDF extraction, recommendations |
| File storage | Cloudflare R2                     | University prospectus PDFs                    |
| Hosting      | Cloudflare Pages                  | Auto-deploy from GitHub, global CDN           |
| Payments     | PayFast                           | SA-native payment gateway for listings        |
| Email        | Resend                            | Job alert digests, student notifications      |
| Analytics    | Google Analytics + Search Console | Traffic, SEO, conversion tracking             |

## Running cost breakdown

| Service         | Provider                 | Monthly cost              |
|-----------------|--------------------------|---------------------------|
| Hosting         | Cloudflare Pages         | R0 (free tier)            |
| Database & auth | Supabase                 | R0 (free tier)            |
| Domain (.co.za) | Afrihost / Domains.co.za | ~R7/mo (R80/yr)           |
| AI engine       | Anthropic Claude API     | ~R90/mo (500 analyses)    |
| Email alerts    | Resend                   | R0 (free up to 3,000/mo)  |
| Payments        | PayFast                  | R0 + 3.5% per transaction |
| TOTAL to start  |                          | ~R97/month                |

## How the AI engine works

- Admin uploads university prospectus PDF to Cloudflare R2 storage
- Claude API reads the PDF and extracts: APS minimums per course, subject requirements, fees, application closing dates
- Extracted data is stored in Supabase PostgreSQL database
- Same process repeats for bursary documents and accommodation listings
- Student enters matric marks → platform calculates APS score live
- Student selects interests, province, funding situation
- Claude API cross-references student profile against all institutions in database
- Returns ranked list of universities, courses, bursaries and accommodation with % match scores

## BUILD ROADMAP

# 12-week plan to launch

Target: live by 1 August 2026 — giving 2 months of SEO momentum before matric exams start in October and results drop in January. Total build cost: ~R97/month.

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## Foundation

Weeks 1–2

- Register zenzeleguide.co.za at Afrihost (~R80/year)
- Create Cloudflare, Supabase, and GitHub accounts (all free)
- Run: `npx create-next-app@latest zenzele-guide --typescript --tailwind --app`
- Connect GitHub repo to Cloudflare Pages for auto-deploy
- Design Supabase database schema: institutions, courses, bursaries, jobs, students, results

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## Homepage & public site

Weeks 2–3

- Build homepage: hero, how-it-works (4 steps), stats, testimonials, CTA
- Create 10 SEO blog/guide pages before launch for Google ranking
- Apply for Google AdSense (takes 2–4 weeks for approval)
- Set up Google Analytics and Search Console

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## AI student portal

Weeks 3–6

- Build multi-step student form: subject marks, APS calculator, interests, preferences
- Build admin PDF upload with Claude API extraction of APS requirements and course data
- Build AI recommendation engine: match student profile to institutions and bursaries
- Add accommodation suggestions linked to top-matched institution

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## Jobs board

Weeks 6–9

- Build filterable jobs board: search, type filter, province filter, saved listings
- Create individual SEO-optimised listing pages for each job/bursary
- Build employer self-serve posting form with PayFast payment integration
- Set up WhatsApp Business broadcast channel and Resend email digest alerts

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## Launch & grow

Weeks 10–12

- Create @ZenzeleGuide TikTok, Instagram, Facebook — post APS tips, NSFAS guides daily
- Launch WhatsApp Channel "Zenzele Guide SA" with daily job and bursary broadcasts
- Approach Eskom, Transnet, Anglo American, DPSA for free trial featured listings
- Enable AdSense and PayFast — revenue goes live on day one
- Target: live before 1 August 2026 to capture November–January matric season traffic

## LAUNCH CHECKLIST

# 21 things to do before going live

## This week — get started immediately

|   |                                                                                 |        |
|---|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------|
| ■ | <b>Register zenzeleguide.co.za</b><br>Afrihost or Domains.co.za — ~R80/year     | R80/yr |
| ■ | <b>Create Cloudflare account</b><br>Free — DNS, CDN, Pages hosting              | Free   |
| ■ | <b>Create Supabase account</b><br>Free — database, auth, file storage           | Free   |
| ■ | <b>Create GitHub account and repository</b><br>Free — version control and CI/CD | Free   |
| ■ | <b>Get Anthropic Claude API key</b><br>claude.ai → Settings → API Keys          | Do now |

## Build the platform

|   |                                                                                                                   |      |
|---|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------|
| ■ | <b>Run: <code>npx create-next-app@latest zenzele-guide</code></b><br>Sets up Next.js with TypeScript and Tailwind | Code |
| ■ | <b>Connect repo to Cloudflare Pages</b><br>Auto-deploys on every GitHub push                                      | Code |
| ■ | <b>Build Supabase database schema</b><br>Tables: institutions, courses, bursaries, jobs, students, results        | Code |
| ■ | <b>Build the homepage</b><br>Hero, how-it-works, stats, testimonials, CTA                                         | Code |
| ■ | <b>Build the student portal (4-step flow)</b><br>Results → interests → AI analysis → matched recommendations      | Code |
| ■ | <b>Build the admin portal</b><br>PDF upload + AI extraction + job posting + analytics                             | Code |
| ■ | <b>Build the jobs board</b><br>Filterable listings, individual pages, employer posting, saved jobs                | Code |
| ■ | <b>Set up WhatsApp Business account</b><br>For job alert broadcasts — biggest free traffic driver                 | Free |

## Revenue setup

|   |                                                                                   |      |
|---|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------|
| ■ | <b>Apply for Google AdSense</b><br>Needs live site with content — takes 2–4 weeks | Free |
|---|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------|

|                               |                                                                                                               |          |
|-------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| ■                             | <b>Create PayFast account</b><br>SA payment gateway for featured listing fees                                 | Do now   |
| ■                             | <b>Set up featured listing tiers</b><br>Free standard / R950 featured / R2,100 premium                        | Code     |
| ■                             | <b>Approach 3 companies for free trial listings</b><br>Eskom, Transnet, Anglo American — build content        | Do now   |
| <b>Marketing &amp; launch</b> |                                                                                                               |          |
| ■                             | <b>Create @ZenzeleGuide TikTok and Instagram</b><br>Post APS tips, NSFAS guides, matric countdown content     | Free     |
| ■                             | <b>Create Zenzele Guide Facebook page</b><br>SA parents and students still use Facebook heavily               | Free     |
| ■                             | <b>Create WhatsApp Channel: Zenzele Guide SA</b><br>Broadcast daily jobs, bursary deadlines, varsity tips     | Free     |
| ■                             | <b>Write 10 SEO blog posts before launch</b><br>"Wits APS 2026", "NSFAS application", "Top learnerships" etc. | Do now   |
| ■                             | <b>Launch publicly before 1 August</b><br>Critical — need 2 months of SEO before matric results in January    | Critical |

## NEXT STEPS

## Start building today

Everything in this document can be built by a single developer within 12 weeks, launched for under R100/month, and generating meaningful revenue by month 3. The window is now — 600,000 South African students write matric every year, and none of them have a platform like this.

**Your first command — run this to start:**

```
npx create-next-app@latest zenzele-guide --typescript --tailwind --app
```

### Immediate priorities (this week)

- Register zenzeleguide.co.za — before someone else does
- Create Cloudflare, Supabase, and GitHub accounts
- Get your Anthropic API key from claude.ai
- Run the Next.js setup command above
- Create @ZenzeleGuide on TikTok and Instagram
- Create Zenzele Guide Facebook page
- Start writing your first 3 SEO blog posts
- Apply for Google AdSense as soon as the site has content

### Why now is the right time

600,000+ SA students write matric every year — results drop in January, creating a massive organic search wave.

No existing SA platform combines AI-powered APS matching + bursaries + jobs + accommodation in one place.

Cloudflare, Supabase, Next.js, and Claude API all have free tiers — total MVP cost is ~R97/month.

The SA student audience is highly valuable to advertisers (banks, telcos, insurers, education brands).

A launch by August 2026 gives 5+ months of SEO compounding before the January results rush.

**zenzeleguide.co.za**

*"Do it yourself — but not alone."*